



Fearless leader: “Whatever he wants from the team, he’ll be doing it first,” Moeen Ali says of Ben Stokes. From setting the tone with aggression to embodying clarity in vision, Stokes has reshaped England’s Test mindset with actions, not just words. GETTY IMAGES

up on it. That’s why players are always working to get better.

When you’re with a franchise, you give everything for that team. But once you’re playing against each other, you’re still trying to find ways to get each other out. What I really like about this series is seeing players like Harry Brook and Nitish Kumar Reddy, who know each other from franchises, still trying to unsettle each other. It’s a healthy kind of aggression. Nothing over the top and it’s been great for both the series and for Test cricket.

Test cricket is becoming faster with aggressive batting. Do you worry about the decline of batting craft?

Not just in red-ball, even in T20 cricket, where teams and players are knocking the ball around a bit even in not so difficult situations. So, that’s kind of gone out the window.

Bit in a way, in Test cricket, it’s great to see K.L. Rahul, who I think is one of the best players in the world. And I’ve always thought that about him. He’s been amazing on this trip so far. You can still see he’s playing that sort of classical Test match innings, which is amazing to see. And you still have players like that.

Then you have Ben Duckett, who just takes the bowling on and plays really nicely as well. So there’s a skill involved. He’s got quick in Test cricket. It’s still a great skill. But there’s still plenty of room for those KL Rahuls, that classy sort of Test innings. Rahul, as we know, has scored many runs in T20 cricket quickly as well. So, it’s amazing that he can do all of that. But yeah, it’s great to see different types of batting to manage at the end. I think those guys with really good techniques will be there for longer.

Since your retirement, England has struggled to find a spin-bowling all-rounder. Are all-rounders becoming redundant?

The game is going in such a way that I think you just need to be generally an all-rounder. And it does take a different type of mindset.

Throughout my years, even before I played for England, I always felt like I was an all-rounder in the development. And it has a different mindset to it, where I think if you’re going to bat, you’re trying to be the best in both, the best that you can be. And I think it’s very difficult in this day and age, unless you’re outstanding, to be just the lone spinner or just the batter. But especially as a spinner, this is where, obviously, with England, it’s great to see Liam Dawson back in the side because he does bring a bit of batting as well. He has been doing really well over the years in County cricket. The all-rounders will still be good. I think more than spinning all-rounders, what a team like India definitely needs is a batting all-rounder, or a seam bowling all-rounder because that would make them a really strong force in any condition.

Someone like Ben Stokes is outstanding. He bowls his heart out and bats in the top six. That would be the ideal kind of player that a team would look for. Australia has probably got a few now, with someone like Cameron Green. So, there’s some really, really good players coming through as